

AM7 Job Aid: Call A Radio Net

Guidance for calling a Radio Net.

General Instructions

The net is defined in Army MARS publication AM-6. The time period of the net is 24 hours each day and is free-net for most hours. Directed net activity may only occur at certain scheduled hours.

Directed Net activity is controlled by the Net Control Station (NCS). Directed Nets should be brief, and Net Control Stations should work to conclude the net as quickly as possible so that all persons can go back about their other business without unnecessary delay.

A Free Net runs over a long periods of time and there may not be a NCS. Those stations not assigned to guard the net can come and go as they please. Radio calls can be made without going through the NCS.

This job-aid contains examples of radio calls made by the Net Control Station and other stations. Noted in these examples is the ACP-125* schematic's format lines. These lines are for reference and not verbalized.

1. Determine the optimum frequency.

The optimum frequency is the frequency that will provide the best RF coverage over the Area of Operation defined for your net. Use the ITS HF Propagation VOACAP software tool to determine best frequency. Because of Mixed Path Distances (ref FM 11-65), a single frequency may not serve all areas and expect to use relays when operating over a large area.

The optimum frequency is selected at the discretion of the NCS based on the propagation conditions at the time, considering time of day, season, and 11 year cycle. Use predictive software tools, such as VOACAP.

2. Net Call Up

The following procedure does not include undesirable preambles and personnel serving as NCS should strive to perform this task without the use of the script. Leadership at every level should strive to maintain simplicity and keep net call-ups as concise as possible.

The first call to the net should contain the words "This is a Directed Net", and these words may be included in following calls, as required by the circumstances.

It is generally desirable to identify stations holding traffic first.

(f12) **ALL STATIONS THIS NET,**
(f13) **THIS IS (NCS Call Sign)**
(f14) **THIS IS A DIRECTED NET**
(f16) **OVER**

(f12) **STATIONS WITH TRAFFIC,**
(f13) **THIS IS (NCS Call Sign)**
(f14) **THIS IS A DIRECTED NET**
(f16) **OVER**

Use the word Exempt to exclude certain stations from the net call. For example, if you wanted to call for station other than MARS stations first:

(f12) **ALL STATIONS THIS NET,**
(f12) **EXEMPT MARS STATIONS**
(f13) **THIS IS (NCS Call Sign)**
(f16) **OVER**

Stations that match the conditions of the call up should now call in making abbreviated calls using full call signs. **

(fl3) **THIS IS (Call-Sign)**
(fl16) **OVER**



Note that a pause here is not desired.

*A full call-sign is normally used to establish communications with new stations ***

The Net Control Station shall keep a running log sheet of the net and:

- Note all stations checking into net.
- Note the signal strength of each station.
- Note the traffic listed and the precedence.
- Note who relays whom.

Pause for a few seconds after the last station is heard to allow enough time for everyone to call in.

3. Answer Calling Stations

(fl2) **(Call Sign),**
(fl2) **(Call Sign) WITH ROUTINE
FOR (Call Sign),**
(fl2) **(Call Sign) WITH TWO PRIORITY
FOR (Call Sign), (ETC)**
(fl3) **THIS IS (NCS Call Sign)**
(fl12) **ROGER**
(fl16) **OUT**

- It is advisable to deal with stations holding traffic first. You may decide to answer and provide instruction to only those stations holding traffic first, and deal with the rest of the net later.
- When answering the calling stations, list the call signs of the station stations heard in alphabetical order.

(fl2) **(Call Sign), and**
(fl2) **(Call Sign),**
(fl12) **MOVE TO (FREQUENCY) AND CALL
(CALLSIGN) TO PASS TRAFFIC**
(fl16) **OUT**

- Include precedence of traffic listed and number of messages if more than one.
- Stations use full call signs when first establishing communications with the net ** then use abbreviated call signs in all following communications (*an instruction to use abbreviated call signs is not required or desired*)

Refer to ACP125 for Authentication and Challenge procedure if required.*

4. Direct A Station To Make A Net Call /

- Select a station with good performance that is likely to cover areas not covered by your station.
- Don't ask. Direct.
- Assign as many stations as required to cover the Area of Operation to Alternate Net Control Station (ANCS).

(fl2) **(Call Sign)**

(fl3) **THIS IS (NCS Call Sign)**

(fl12) **YOU ARE ALTERNATE NET CONTROL
MAKE A NET CALL.**

(fl16) **OUT.**

4A. The ANCS Station Makes A Call For Additional Stations:

(fl2) **ALL STATIONS THIS NET,**

(fl3) **THIS IS (Call Sign of Assigned Station)**

(fl12) **ADDITIONAL STATIONS FOR THE NET
OVER**

- Note all new stations checking into net that you hear.
- Note the traffic listed and the precedence.
- Note signal strength of these stations.
- Note who relays whom.
- Pause for a few seconds after the last station is heard to allow enough time for everyone to call in.

4B. The ANCS Station Answers The Additional Stations:

(fl2) **(Call Sign),**

(fl2) **(Call Sign) WITH ROUTINE FOR (Call Sign),**

(fl2) **(Call Sign) WITH TWO ROUTINE FOR (Call Sign), (ETC)**

(fl3) **THIS IS (Call Sign of Assigned Station)**

(fl12) **ROGER,**

(fl16) **OUT.**

- List the call signs of the station stations heard in alphabetical order
- Include precedence of traffic listed and number of messages if more than one.
- Use abbreviated call signs whenever appropriate
- Read back all information so the NCS and other net stations can copy the readback.

4C. The NCS Acknowledges The Additional Stations.

(fl3) **THIS IS (NCS Call Sign)**

(fl12) **ROGER BY INTERCEPT**

(fl16) **OUT**

This example assumes the NCS copied the additional stations, or the ANCS read back by intercept. This is the expected behavior and the ANCS should not normally have to list this information for the

NCS.

Note: At this time, the NCS has made ONE call for stations, and has directed at least one other station to make a net call. All stations that are on time for the net have had an opportunity to call into the net. Additional calls for stations ARE NOT made at this time.

5. The NCS Transmits A List Of All Stations In The Net.

(fl2) **ALL STATIONS THIS NET,**
 (fl3) **THIS IS (NCS Call Sign)**
 (fl4) **DO NOT ANSWER,**
 (fl12) **THE FOLLOWING STATIONS ARE IN THE NET:**
9__ __, 9__ __, (ETC),
 (fl16) **OUT**

- This list is the complete net at this time, and establishes the order in which stations will answer.
- This list is verbalized.
- List the call signs of the stations heard in the order (alphabetical order is standard, although other conventions may apply).

6. Call Stations Listing Traffic

(fl2) **(CALL SIGN OF CALLED STATION)**
 (fl3) **THIS IS (NCS CALL SIGN)**
 (fl12) **CALL YOUR STATION,**
QSY TO YOUR WORKING FREQUENCY,
AND PASS (PRECEDENCE),
 (fl16) **OUT**

(fl2) **(CALL SIGN OF CALLED STATION)**
 (fl3) **THIS IS (NCS CALL SIGN)**
 (fl12) **MOVE TO (FREQUENCY) AND CALL,**
(CALLSIGN) TO PASS (PRECEDENCE)
 (fl16) **OUT**

- It is not normally desired for the NCS to take traffic.
- When there is a collection point for data, the NCS should designate that station and assign them to another frequency.
- Handle traffic for the entire net before traffic for individual stations.
- Call each station listing traffic in order of Precedence,
- Proceed from Highest Precedence to Lowest Precedence
- Unless the traffic is for all stations in the net, DO NOT allow the traffic to be passed on the net frequency while the net is directed.
- The NCS should expect that stations bringing traffic to the net for a specific station have already selected a clear working frequency to pass traffic. Do not allow discussion of the frequency change to be more than a simple statement telling the other station to "QSY TO ____".
- Traffic may also be passed in free net after the directed net concludes.

7. Poll The Net For Information (if appropriate)

(fl2) **(CALL SIGN OF CALLED STATION)**

(fl3) **THIS IS (NCS Call Sign)**

(fl12) **YOUR INFORMATION FOR THE NET,**

(fl16) **OVER**

- Take this step only if polling the net for information is appropriate. Polling for information
- Call each station in the net in the order established in Step 5.
- Make note of any relevant information and required action.

8. Make A Net Call Up For Late Stations

(fl2) **ALL STATIONS THIS NET,**

(fl3) **THIS IS (NCS CALL SIGN)**

(fl12) **ADDITIONAL STATIONS FOR THE NET,**

(fl16) **OVER**

*A full call-sign is normally used to establish communications with new stations ***

A Net Call Up for late stations is optional, and if it is made, is done after all other net business is concluded.

- Note all late stations checking into net.
- Note the traffic listed and the precedence.
- Note signal strength of these stations.
- Note who relays whom.
- Pause for 10-15 seconds after the last station is heard to allow enough time for everyone to call in.

8A. Dispose of Late Stations

(fl2) **(CALL SIGN OF LATE STATION)**

(fl3) **THIS IS (NCS CALL SIGN)**

(fl16) **OVER**

Additionally, handle any traffic listed as in Step 6
Request any Information for the net as in Step 7

9. Make the Net Free, Release Stations From The Net.

(fl2) **ALL STATIONS THIS NET,**

(fl3) **THIS IS (NCS CALL SIGN)**

(fl12) **THIS IS A FREE NET,**

(fl16) **OUT**

This language is an alternate to the traditional direction to Close Stations, which is a mandatory directive to turn off station equipment. This language acknowledges that operation between stations may continue as required after the directed net activity (in Free Net), but stations are no longer

required to maintain the net and may close at their discretion in a Free Net condition.

Directed Net Activity should may continue as long as it is necessary, but Directed Net Activity should be succinct and conclude as soon as all tasks are complete. There is no requirement to continue the net for any number of minutes, nor is this desirable.

Net Control Stations should strive to complete Directed Net Activity as quickly as possible, and all stations in the net should respect the time of the other net members.

** Note on conformity with ACP125. The Allied Communications Protocol (ACP) 125 is the standard for voice communications for US and Allied forces. It is a collection and colleague of each stakeholder's best practices and experiences which establishes the guidance for radio telephone procedure. Some parts of ACP125 are held to strictly, such as the order of the called and calling stations in a radio call, or the phonetic alphabet, others parts of the procedure are adapted operationally as required. This are many variations of how ACP125 is adapted in practice, yet they all conform to the standard. A broad interpretation that in intuitive and reduces training burden by minimizing procedural facts is desired. Radio Telephone procedures described here follow current US Army practice, further adopted for MARS, and are the result of evolution over the last two decades of continuous conflict alongside coalition and allied forces.*

*** Note on use of full and abbreviated call signs. Normally, the full call-sign is used when a station first identifies itself to a net, so that the net knows who the station is specifically and can distinguish it from all other radio stations. Once that is established, abbreviated call signs are used afterwards. In some cases, such as special teams of MARS stations, the stations in the net are already known to each other and abbreviated call signs are used exclusively. When operating on Army MARS frequencies, it is assumed the prefix of AAR unless otherwise established by first using a full call sign. While this procedure specifies the practice of first using a full call-sign, it is not meant to prohibit the exclusive use of abbreviated call-signs inside defined teams when it is appropriate and unlikely to cause mis-identification, or prohibit AAR prefix stations from using abbreviated call signs exclusively when operating on Army MARS frequencies.*